

The RG File

From colourful headgear to books on geopolitics, from a night at a lounge bar to a trek in Ladakh. The private life of India's most eligible bachelor.



UNITED COLOURS OF CAMPAIGN

During the 2009 elections, he was the party's star campaigner, addressing 102 meetings in 97 constituencies in 35 days. He runs a campaign solely on his charisma and chutzpah. Apart from his now familiar kurtas and keds, this year's sartorial addition is a designer stubble. An impromptu snack break is part of the script as he stops at a local hut, wipes his hands on his kurta, sits cross-legged on the floor to munch a parantha. In Kolkata he stops for mishti doi, in Meerut he chews on sugar cane. But it was the girls from Bathinda who had the last word when they quizzed him on his marriage plans.



CLUB CLASS

He is equally at home in a Dalit's hut as he is in the Capital's trendy restaurants such as Wasabi, Shalom, Smoke House Grill or Ashoka Hotel's Sagar Ratna. While dining out, he makes it a point to be seated at a table at the far end with his back to the entrance. Enjoys taking his nephew Rehan to cricket matches while it is Priyanka who



usually drags him to Bollywood events. Though a cheerful flirt, the country's most eligible bachelor takes care not to be linked with any woman. That does not stop the gossip, however.

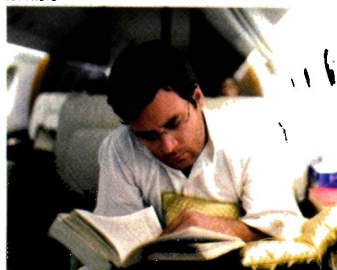
BRAIN AND BRAWN

One of his young MP friends complained that he is always reading some complex book or the other such as tomes on geopolitics. Mahatma Gandhi is an idol for this Gandhi. His quotations are always found on his desk. An exercise buff, he works out at Amratra, the Capital's trendiest gym, doing an hour of cardio followed by 40 minutes of weight training. While at home, his dog, Pidli, is a constant companion. Cricket and boxing are other stress-busters for him.

AP PHOTO



AFP PHOTO



FAMILY FIRST

Most of his sentences are prefixed with a reference to "my sister", while brother-in-law Robert Vadra accompanies him on his bike rides and treks in Ladakh. Priyanka Gandhi joins them for the fashion shows and concerts. It was she who first introduced Rahul to the people of Amethi. An indulgent mother, Sonia is slowly handing over the reins of the party to this next generation Gandhi, who has his father's idealism and his uncle Sanjay's drive.



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HIS MUSE

An impoverished widow from Maharashtra's Vidharbha, Kalavati has become the most visible metaphor for Rahul's politics of empowerment. He used her case to argue the benefits of nuclear deal in



Parliament, claiming that the deal would bring development to far-flung villages. 'Mrs Kala' as she came to be known in Parliament, was just one of the downtrodden families visited by Rahul during his now famous discovery of India tours.